

Q I'm almost 35 weeks and my maternity bra is feeling tight. Can I avoid getting a new bra now?

If your cup size still feels fine, but your bra is tight around your body, you could buy a **bra extender**. This cheap accessory is simply three or four extra sets of eyes that you attach to your existing bra strap so that you can let your bra out a few more inches as your rib cage expands. This saves you from buying a new maternity bra at this late stage.

Q What's the difference between a maternity bra and a nursing bra?

Nursing bras allow easy access during breast-feeding, usually via a clasp that allows you to pull the cup material down. This enables you to feed your baby without having to remove your bra. These bras are designed to avoid placing pressure on your breast tissue, which could lead to blocked ducts and problems with nursing. Maternity bras don't have an access system, but are stretchier and designed to adapt to growing breasts during pregnancy. Women who don't plan to breast-feed sometimes prefer maternity bras after the birth since they don't need accessible cups.

Q I prefer underwire bras. Can I continue wearing these?

It's generally recommended that you avoid wearing underwire bras during pregnancy and while nursing. As your breasts swell, the rigid underwire may dig into your skin and breast tissue, which is especially uncomfortable in pregnancy and can obstruct the blood flow to the breasts. Once you're breast-feeding, pressure from an underwired bra could lead to blocked milk ducts, obstructing the flow of milk, and even leading to mastitis (see p.274-75).

Most maternity and nursing bras are nonwired, but if you definitely prefer underwire bras (those with larger busts might find they offer more support), there are some underwire maternity bras that contain a more flexible wire made from a lightweight alloy. These mold more easily around the breast and avoid putting pressure on breast tissue.

Q My doctor suggested that I wear a bra at night, but that sounds rather uncomfortable. Is this really necessary?

If your breasts are very tender, you may find that a **lightweight nonwire soft bra will help you to feel more comfortable at night.** You can even buy a soft sleep bra that is designed for maximum comfort while you sleep, or you could try wearing a crop-top bra. After the birth, if you are leaking milk and using breast pads, then wearing a bra at night will make it easier to keep the pads in place (see p.275).

You may find that you start to outgrow your usual bra from as early as 8 to 10 weeks into pregnancy. It's a good idea to be measured every couple of months by a professional bra fitter to check that your current bra still fits you properly.

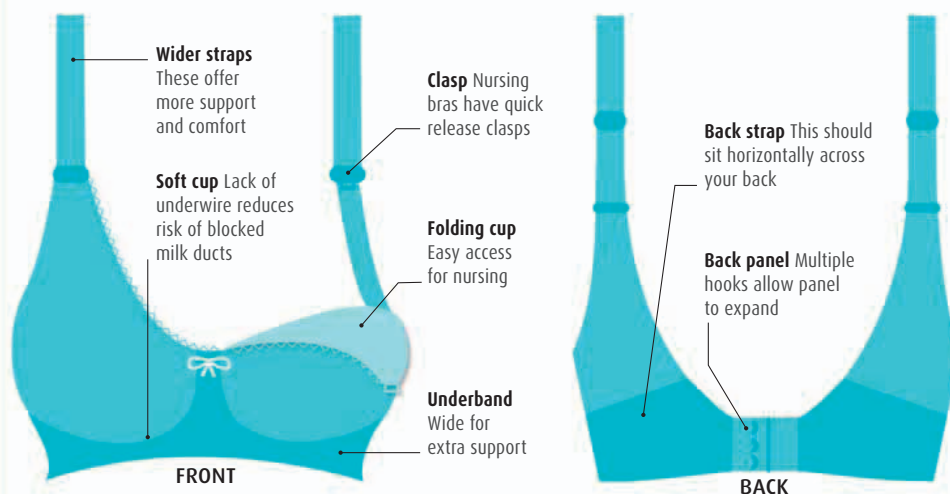
Q What do I look for when choosing maternity and nursing bras?

Comfort and support are key. Don't be tempted to estimate your new bra size—it's definitely a good idea to ask a trained bra fitter to measure you and make sure that you buy styles of maternity and nursing bras that fit you perfectly.

Look for bras made of breathable cotton or cotton and lycra with some stretch in the cup. Wide adjustable shoulder straps will provide good support for your bigger breasts, but make sure the straps don't dig in. Likewise, the back strap should fit comfortably close to your body without being too tight, and should sit straight—if it rides up, the bra is too big.

A wide, curved underband at the front accommodates your growing belly. Choose maternity and nursing bras with four sets of

hooks and eyes on the back panel so you can adjust the fit of your bra. Your rib cage expands in pregnancy and shrinks back after the birth, so when you're buying a bra early in pregnancy, make sure it fits on the tightest hook so you can let the strap out as your body changes; then when buying a nursing bra toward the end of pregnancy, choose one that fits on the loosest setting. Check that you can open and close the nursing bra cup easily with one hand.



Bra anatomy Maternity and nursing bras are designed in the same way, with supportive back and shoulder straps. Seamless bras are good if your nipples are tender. Nursing bras have fasteners on the shoulders or central panel that open and close each cup easily.